

ROUGH CUT KAVEREE BAMZAI

The Pappu Culture



Forgive me for laughing out loud but ever since I read that Rahul Gandhi is conducting a talent search for a new generation of full-timers in the Congress, I haven't quite been myself. The not-so-young Gandhi, we

are told, is part of a board that is conducting extensive interviews of young hopefuls. Yes, this from a man who four years into his adopted profession still shies away from one-on-one interviews, who refuses to do as Mummy tells him (mainly buckle up and run the party for God's sake) or even put the prime minister out of his misery by becoming one himself. It's tempting to dismiss him as a babalog but then that would be doing a disservice to his late father's memory, who could be faulted for everything but his enthusiasm and whose team at least had some experience of other lives. No, Gandhi junior is like the new breed of young men who are crowding Bollywood and have already split several carefully built empires in business. He is a pappu, as the song goes, ironically in the movie of yet another new pappu.

What are the hallmarks of a pappu? *Rado ki ghadi haathon main/perfume Gucci wala? Pappu ke pass hai PA/karta hai France main holiday? Think Deora, Dikshit and Prasada junior? No, more than that.* What they have in common



SAURABH SINGH

is that they have yet to prove themselves worthy of their famous last names and have been thrust upon an unsuspecting party with little preparation. At least in the movies the audience has the liberty of rejecting dynasty's children. The carnage of some recent films, starring Ranbir Kapoor, Sikander, Adhyayan Suman, and Mimoh is testimony to it. But in politics, unfortunately, fortunes don't change every Friday, but every five years. And there's no finishing school to smoothen the rough edges.

The good part is that misery loves company. For the past eight years, Americans have been suffering the silliness of pappu-in-chief, a man who can't complete a sentence but expected to finish a war in Iraq. If they had indeed voted for Al Gore, the world would have been short of a world-class documentary but may have been much greener and safer. I think it's time to take a leaf out of Hollywood's book. One reason I think global celebrities give their children oddball names (Suri Cruise, Shiloh Jolie-Pitt and Apple Paltrow-Martin) is that they want them to embrace anonymity. Smart move and one that should be instantly aped.

SIPRA DAS



Mayawati



Sharma

Thumping Her Iron Fist

LUCKNOW It's a cleansing act that Chief Minister Mayawati is bent on pursuing, even against her own partymen. Ever since she assumed office in May last year, she has clamped down on BSP MLAs and ministers who are accused of criminal acts. The latest to earn her ire is Bhagwan Sharma alias Guddu Pandit, an MLA from Dibai in Bulandshahar district. He was arrested by the Noida police on June 29 on charges of rape, molestation, illegal confinement and criminal assault on a woman.

Sheetal Birla, a research scholar at Agra University, had alleged that she met Sharma at a wedding and they became "close" to each other. Says Brij Lal, additional director-general of police, "They married at a temple. But when she claimed legal rights, the MLA told her that he was already married with two children and that she would be his mistress." When she refused, she was allegedly kept in illegal confinement by

Sharma, who repeatedly raped and assaulted her. Following Birla's complaint, the BSP MLA has been arrested and sent to jail. Sharma is reported to be one of over 150 MLAs in the state with criminal cases against them.

Soon after reports of his "affair" with Birla had surfaced, Mayawati had ordered action against him, making it amply clear that she would not hesitate to act against her own party cadres if they were found to be misusing their authority. Earlier, she had directed strict action against ministers Anand Sen Yadav and Yamuna Prasad Nishad and MP Rama Kant Yadav.

But for Mayawati, it may well turn into a Catch 22 situation. While on the one hand she is gaining popularity among the masses for her firm stand against erring partymen, on the other hand she is losing faith of her MLAs, which may spell trouble for the "iron lady" in the long run.

by Subhash Mishra